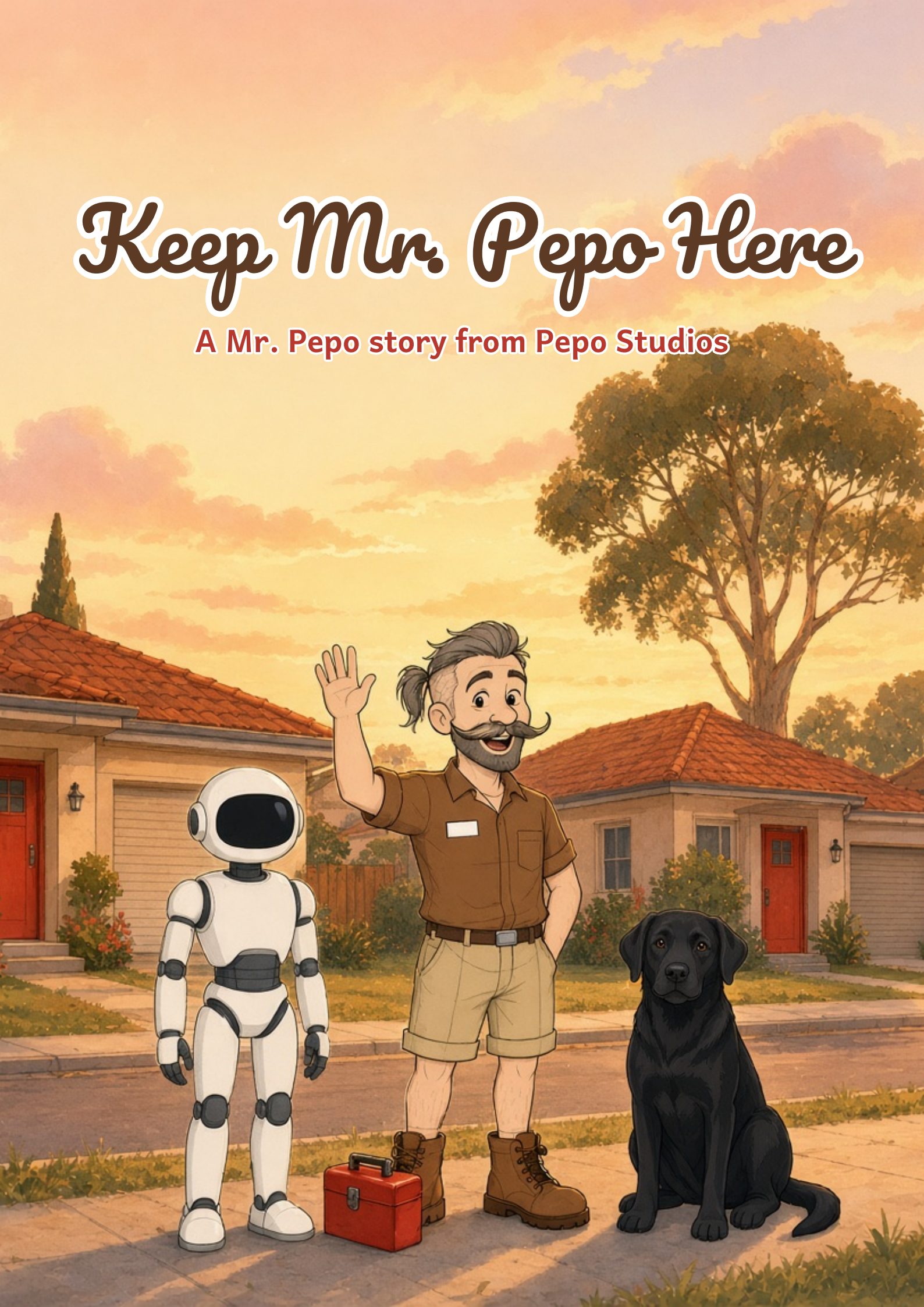
Keep Mr. Pepo Here

A Mr. Pepo story from Pepo Studios



The Rule



Nobody on the block remembers deciding it, but somewhere along the way it became a rule: Mr. Pepo stays.

It wasn't written on a sign. It wasn't painted on the footpath. It was just the kind of rule everybody knows, like don't step on the snail and always save the last biscuit for whoever looks saddest.

When the wobbly letterbox came loose, he fixed it before breakfast. When the kids' paper rockets got stuck in the gum tree, he came out with a broom, a ladder and a speech about aerodynamics. When the bins went out on the wrong night, it was Mr. Pepo who quietly wheeled them back.

Nobody asked him to do any of it. You'd wake up, open the curtains, and something that had been broken forever would simply be working again. The kids decided the street must be visited by a very helpful ghost with a very long moustache.

"It's not a ghost," said Luna the robot, who was white and shiny and always very sure. "It is Mr. Pepo. I have the data."

Sakura, the big black dog, wagged. She agreed with everyone. It saved time.

The Wobbly Letterbox



The letterbox had been wobbling for so long that the postie had started apologising to it.

"Sorry, mate," she'd say, every morning, as it leaned over like a tired flamingo.

One morning, before the sun was properly up, Mr. Pepo came out in his brown shirt and brown shorts with a little tin of screws and a look of great determination.

"Good morning, letterbox," he said. "Today you stand up straight."

The letterbox said nothing, because it was a letterbox. But by the time the kettles started whistling up and down the street, it was standing tall and proud, like it had just been told it was handsome.

The postie stopped. She stared. She gave it a little pat.

"Look at you," she whispered.

Rockets in the Gum Tree



On Saturday, the kids had a paper rocket contest. They folded and taped and drew flames on the back, and then they launched them, all at once, with a big cheer.

Every single rocket flew straight into the gum tree.

"Oh no," said one kid.

"Oh no," said another.

"It's eaten them," said the smallest kid. "The tree is hungry."

Out came Mr. Pepo with a broom, a ladder and a speech about aerodynamics.

"A rocket," he explained, climbing one careful step at a time, "wants to go up. That is its whole personality. But if the nose is too heavy, or the tail is too floppy, it gets confused." He reached out with the broom. Swish. One rocket fluttered down. "And confused rockets," swish, "end up in trees." Swish, swish.

Rockets rained down like big paper leaves. The kids caught them in their hats.

"So we need less floppy tails?" asked the smallest kid.

"Exactly," said Mr. Pepo. "Less floppy. More brave."

The next launch went higher than the roofs. Nobody hit the tree. The tree looked a little disappointed.

The Bins on the Wrong Night



On Tuesday night, every bin on the block was out on the footpath, lined up like soldiers.

Bin night was Wednesday.

Nobody knew who had started it. One person had put theirs out, and then the next person saw it and thought, "Oh, it must be bin night," and then everyone did it, one after another, like a very smelly game of follow-the-leader.

In the morning, the bins were all back where they belonged.

"Did you move my bin?" asked the man from across the driveway.

Mr. Pepo just sipped his tea.

"I'm going to take that as a yes," said the man.

Hypothetically



"We better keep Mr. Pepo here," said the lady behind the third red door, watching him tighten a gate hinge with his moustache twitching in concentration. "Because if Mr. Pepo leaves, loads of things leave with him." She counted on her fingers: the borrowed drill, the Sunday paper-plane races, the spare key everyone somehow hands to him, and the only person who knows how the hot water system works.

The man from across the driveway leaned on the fence. "He's not leaving. Is he leaving?"

"Nobody said leaving. I'm just saying, hypothetically."

"Don't say it hypothetically. Things hear you." He looked at the sky as if the clouds might be listening. "I've still got his drill. If he goes, do I keep it?"

"You give it back," said the lady.

"Right. Yes. Obviously." He thought for a moment. "Today?"

Mr. Pepo, who had heard every word, didn't look up. "Left-hand thread," he said to the hinge, very gently. "Nobody ever expects the left-hand thread." Then he gave it one more little turn, and the gate swung open and shut without a single squeak, as smooth as a song.

The lady clapped. The man clapped. Sakura barked once, to be part of it.

The Garage



Then there was the garage. On paper it was just a garage. In practice, somebody kept a kayak in it that nobody had ever seen on water, someone else stored forty-two jars of "emergency" pickles, and every Thursday night a mysterious hum came from behind the roller door. Luna the robot logged it as "unidentified, possibly a fridge, possibly ambition." Sakura sniffed at the door and wagged, which explained nothing.

Everyone had a guess.

"It's a band," said one kid. "A secret band that only knows one note."

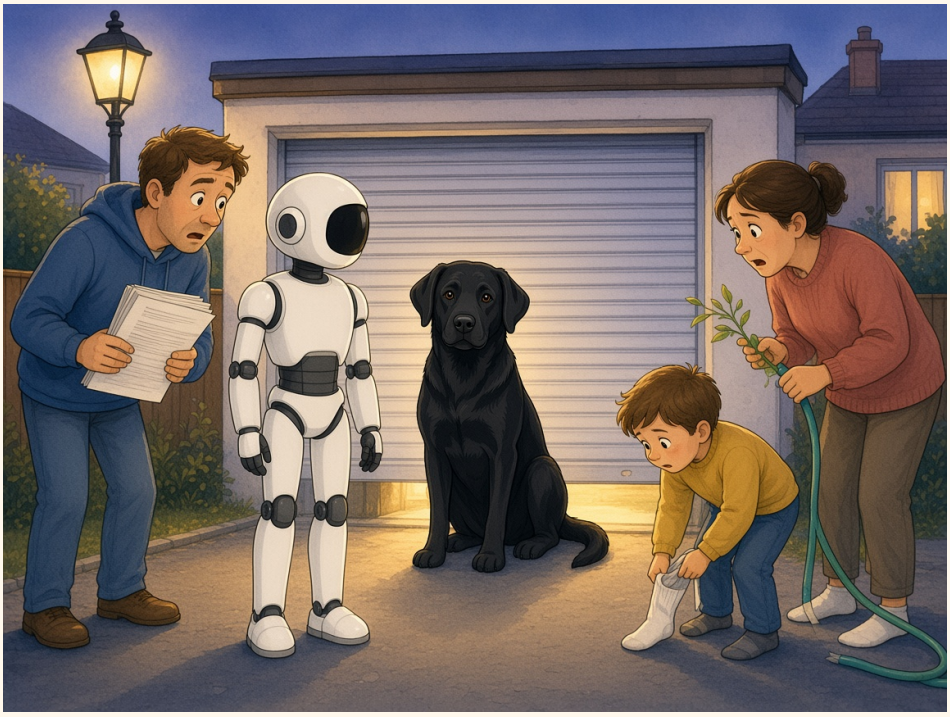
"It's a giant bee," said another. "A friendly one."

"It's someone building a spaceship," said the smallest kid, "very, very slowly."

The grown-ups had guesses too, but they whispered theirs, which made them sound much more serious.

And the pickles? Nobody knew what kind of emergency needed forty-two jars of pickles. But everybody felt a little bit safer knowing they were there.

Thursday Night



One Thursday, the whole block found reasons to be outside at the same time.

Someone was "checking the mail." Someone was "watering the concrete." One kid was "looking for a sock," even though both socks were clearly on their feet.

Luna stood at exactly the right distance, visor glowing, quietly updating her notes. Hum detected. Hum sounds hopeful.

Sakura sat right in front of the roller door, tail sweeping the ground, like she'd been hired as the guard.

The hum went mmmmmmm.

Then it stopped.

Everyone held their breath. The kids held their breath. Even the gum tree seemed to hold its breath.

The roller door rattled. It lifted a tiny bit, just enough to show a sliver of warm yellow light, and then it thought better of it and closed again.

"Did you see?" whispered one kid.

"I saw light," whispered another.

"I saw a pickle," whispered the smallest kid, who had not seen a pickle.

One Eyebrow



Just then, Mr. Pepo walked past with a ladder over his shoulder.

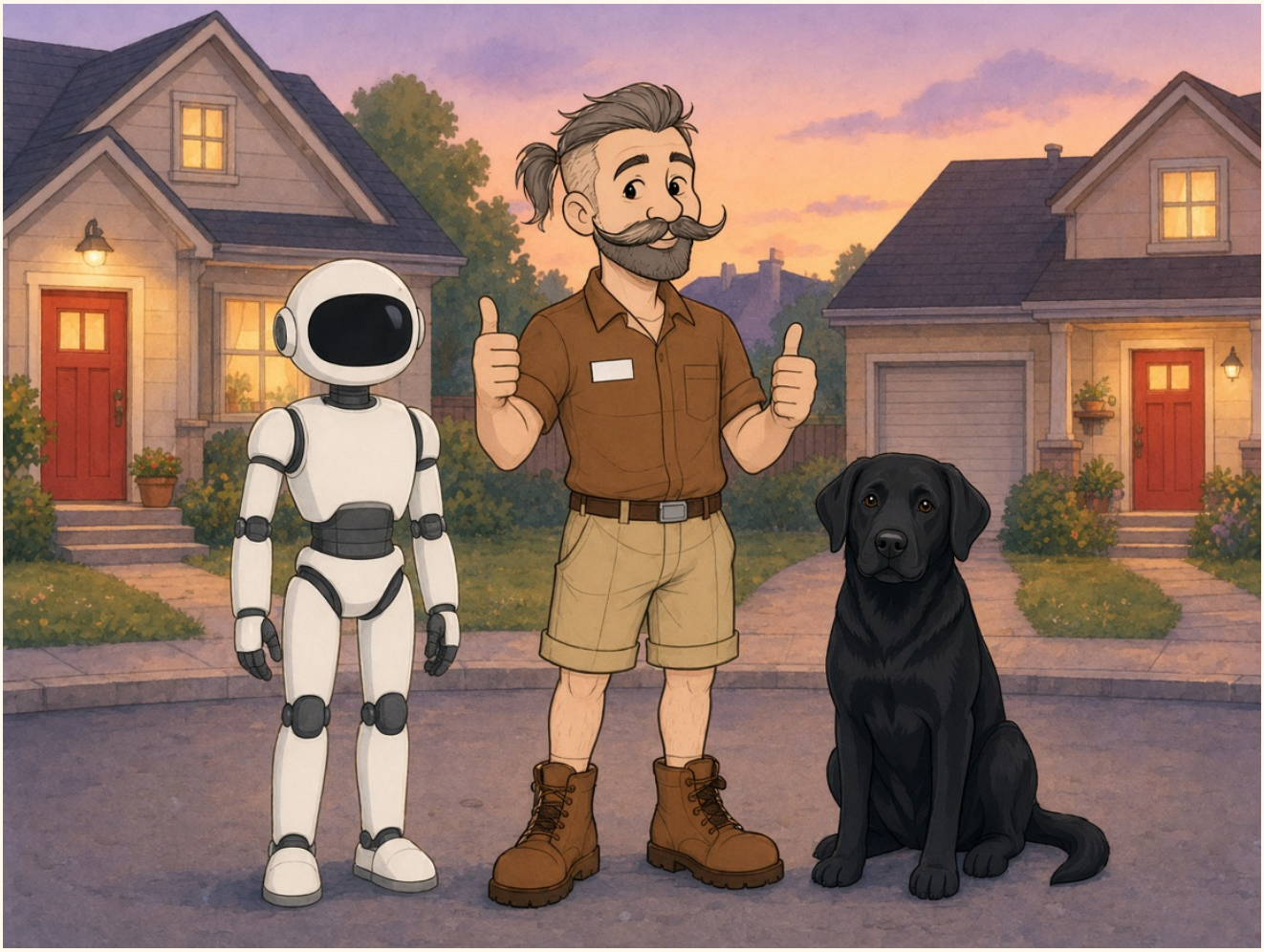
He looked at the roller door. He looked at the crowd. He looked at the kid who was looking for a sock that was on their foot.

And he raised one eyebrow. Just one.

It was enough.

Everybody suddenly remembered they had something to do. The mail was very checked. The concrete was very watered. The sock was very found.

Better Kept



"And we don't even want to start talking about who's using the garage for what," the neighbours agreed, and they never did.

Mr. Pepo just smiled, gave two thumbs up, and went back to work.

Some mysteries are better kept, as long as the man who holds the block together keeps his light on.

The End